



HOW-TO GUIDE

Boat Detailing

Every boat service we sell, step by step, with the exact product for each one. Gelcoat is not car paint, so read the rules page before your first job.

The Kit

Exact products. Anything in **red** is not on the shelf yet, see Still Need To Buy below.

PRODUCT	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT'S FOR
Mainstream Marine Boat Cleaner	Boat wash soap	The general wash on hull, deck, and topsides.
Star brite Instant Hull Cleaner	Acid-based stain remover	The brown waterline stain. Wipes off without scrubbing.
3M Marine Restorer and Wax	Compound and wax in one	Light to moderate gelcoat oxidation.
3M Super Duty Rubbing Compound	Heavy compound	Chalky, badly oxidized gelcoat that the Restorer won't fix.
3M Marine Finesse-it	Finishing polish	Removes compound haze and brings up the shine.
Collinite 845 Insulator Wax	Marine paste wax	The wax step. Long-lasting and proven on boats.
Marine Maxx Ceramic Coating	Ceramic coating	The Full Ceramic Package.
IMAR Strataglass Cleaner	Clear vinyl cleaner	Isinglass and clear enclosure panels only.
Koch Chemie Green Star	All-purpose cleaner	Non-skid decks and general grime.
Dual-action polisher	You already own this	Compounding and polishing. Slower than a rotary on bad oxidation.

Rules That Don't Change

These apply to every single job. Read them once, follow them always.

- **Always ask permission before you get on or in a boat.** Confirm with the owner or the marina where you can run water and power.
- **Soft-soled, non-marking shoes only.** Black soles leave marks on a white deck that you'll then have to remove for free.
- **Never wax or coat a non-skid deck.** Non-skid exists to stop people slipping. Waxing it makes it slick and someone gets hurt. Clean it, protect it with a dedicated non-skid product if asked, but never wax it.
- **Keep compound and polish off canvas, isinglass, and upholstery.** It stains and it's very hard to get out. Mask what's near your work area.
- **Acid hull cleaner means gloves and eye protection, every time.** Rinse anything it touches that isn't the hull, especially metal fittings.
- **Work in the shade or early in the day.** Gelcoat gets hot fast and product will dry on it.
- **Don't pressure wash decals, graphics, or old canvas stitching up close.** You'll peel or tear them.
- **Photograph existing gelcoat cracks, chips, and damage before you start.** Boats collect damage and you don't want it attributed to you.

Wash

\$200 to \$300 ballpark, custom quote · typical 20 to 30ft boat · about 2 to 3 hours

A thorough wash of the hull, topsides, and deck. Salt, grime, and bird mess off. No compounding, no wax.

1 Rinse everything down first

- Fresh water over the whole boat to knock off salt and loose dirt.
- Salt left on the surface turns into scratches the moment you start scrubbing.

2 Wash top down

- **Mainstream Marine Boat Cleaner** in a bucket, soft brush on a pole for the big flat areas.
- Hardtop and superstructure first, then topsides, then the hull, then the deck last.
- Rinse each section before the soap dries.

3 Non-skid decks

- **Koch Chemie Green Star** diluted, worked in with a stiff deck brush.
- Scrub with the grain of the pattern. Rinse thoroughly, soap left in non-skid gets slippery.

4 Waterline stains

- **Star brite Instant Hull Cleaner** on the brown band at the waterline.
- Gloves and eye protection on. Wipe or spray on, it mostly dissolves the stain without scrubbing.
- Rinse it off completely and don't let it dry on the gelcoat.

5 Clear vinyl and glass

- **IMAR Strataglass Cleaner** on isinglass, nothing else.
- Never use ammonia glass cleaner or anything abrasive on clear vinyl, it goes cloudy permanently and those panels are expensive.

6 Dry

- Chamois or big microfiber on the gelcoat and any bright metal.
- Water spots on a dark hull show badly, so dry as you go rather than at the end.

Watch out. Do not use acid hull cleaner on anodized aluminum, painted surfaces, or polished stainless. It will etch and discolor them.

Done when

- ☐ No salt film left, run a finger over the gelcoat and check.
- ☐ Waterline is clean or clearly improved, and you've told the owner if a stain won't come out.
- ☐ Non-skid is fully rinsed and not slippery.
- ☐ Isinglass is clear with no new scratches.

Wash & Polish

\$450 to \$600 ballpark, custom quote · about **5 to 8 hours**

Everything in the Wash, plus oxidation removal and a gelcoat polish. This is the service for a boat that's gone chalky and dull.

1 Full wash first

- Run every step of the Wash. Compounding a dirty hull grinds dirt into the gelcoat.

2 Test how bad the oxidation is

- Rub a small area with your thumb. If white chalk comes off on your skin, it's oxidized.
- Try **3M Marine Restorer and Wax** on a 2ft square first with a wool or cutting pad on the dual-action polisher.
- If that won't cut it, step up to **3M Super Duty Rubbing Compound**.

3 Compound in sections

- Work 2ft by 2ft. Keep the pad flat and let the machine do the work.
- Keep the pad and the surface slightly damp, never let compound dry on the gelcoat.
- Wipe each section down and check it before moving on.
- Clean the pad often. Gelcoat loads pads up much faster than car paint does.

4 Refine

- **3M Marine Finesse-it** on a polishing pad over everything you compounded.
- This removes the haze the compound leaves and is what actually makes it shine.

5 Wipe down and inspect

- Clean towel over every polished section, then look at it from several angles.
- Gelcoat hides swirls until the light hits right, so move around the boat while you check.

Watch out. Gelcoat is a finite thickness and heavily oxidized boats have already lost some. Don't keep cutting the same spot hoping it improves. If it won't come back after two passes, tell the owner it's at its limit rather than cutting through to the laminate.

Tip. Without a rotary buffer this takes noticeably longer on heavy oxidation. A rotary is the single biggest time-saver for boat work if the volume justifies it.

Done when

- ☐ No chalk transfers to your thumb anywhere on the hull.
- ☐ Gloss is even, no dull patches or swirl trails.
- ☐ No compound residue in rub rails, fittings, or lettering.
- ☐ Owner has been told about any area that couldn't be fully restored.

Wash, Polish & Wax

\$650 to \$850 ballpark, custom quote · about **7 to 10 hours**

Everything in the Wash & Polish, plus a protective marine wax. The polish makes it shine, the wax is what keeps it that way through the season.

1 Wash and polish first

- Complete both services fully before any wax goes on.

2 Wax the gelcoat

- **Collinite 845 Insulator Wax**, thin coat by hand or with a soft foam pad on the machine at low speed.
- Thin is the whole trick. A thick coat is hard to remove and doesn't protect any better.
- Let it haze, then buff off with a clean microfiber.

3 Second coat on the sun-facing surfaces

- Hardtop, foredeck, and anything that bakes all day gets a second coat.
- That's where the UV damage starts and where it'll fail first.

4 Detail the metal

- Polish the stainless rails and fittings while you're at it. It's a small amount of extra time and it's the first thing an owner notices.

Watch out. Non-skid decks do not get waxed. Ever. It's a slip and fall risk and it is not worth the liability.

Done when

- ☐ Water beads tightly across the whole hull.
- ☐ No wax residue in seams, lettering, rub rails, or around fittings.
- ☐ Non-skid areas are clean and completely wax free.
- ☐ Stainless is polished with no wax haze left on it.

Full Ceramic Package

\$1,800 to \$2,400 ballpark, custom quote · often **2 to 3 days**

Wash, full oxidation removal and polish, then a ceramic coating instead of wax. Far better UV and salt protection, and it lasts through seasons rather than months.

1 Wash and full polish

- Every step of Wash & Polish. The coating locks in whatever the surface looks like, so it has to be right first.

2 Prep the surface

- Wipe every surface with an isopropyl alcohol solution or the prep wipe supplied with the coating.
- This strips off the polishing oils. Skip it and the coating will not bond, and it will fail within weeks.

3 Coat in small sections

- **Marine Maxx Ceramic Coating**, following the bottle for temperature and humidity.
- A few drops on the applicator, cross-hatch pattern, 2ft by 2ft at a time.
- Watch for the flash, then buff with a clean microfiber and check with a second one.
- Any coating left to cure on the surface becomes a high spot you have to polish off.

4 Let it cure

- Keep the boat dry and out of rain for the time the manufacturer specifies, usually at least 24 hours.
- Ideally the boat stays out of the water until it's fully cured. Tell the owner this before you start, not after.

5 Hand over care instructions

- Rinse with fresh water after each use. No harsh acid cleaners on the coating.
- This is a premium service, so hand over a written note about how to keep it up.

Watch out. Never coat over oxidation, wax, or polish residue. The whole value of the service depends on the prep being right.

Done when

- ☐ Coating is even everywhere, no high spots, streaks, or rainbow patches.
- ☐ Water sheets and beads hard across the whole hull.
- ☐ Non-skid handled per the coating maker's instructions, and still not slippery.
- ☐ Owner has written care instructions and knows the cure time.

Still Need To Buy

Boat work is quoted per job, so buy as the jobs come in rather than all at once.

ITEM	WHY	ROUGHLY
Star brite Instant Hull Cleaner	Waterline stains are on nearly every boat	\$20-30
3M Super Duty Rubbing Compound	For the badly oxidized boats the Restorer won't fix	\$35-50
3M Marine Finesse-it	Without it, compounded gelcoat stays hazy	\$30-45
IMAR Strataglass Cleaner	The only safe thing for isinglass. Ruining a panel is expensive	\$20-25
Wool and foam pads, marine grade	Gelcoat eats pads much faster than car paint	\$50-80
Rotary buffer (upgrade)	Cuts heavy oxidation in a fraction of the time a DA takes	\$150-300